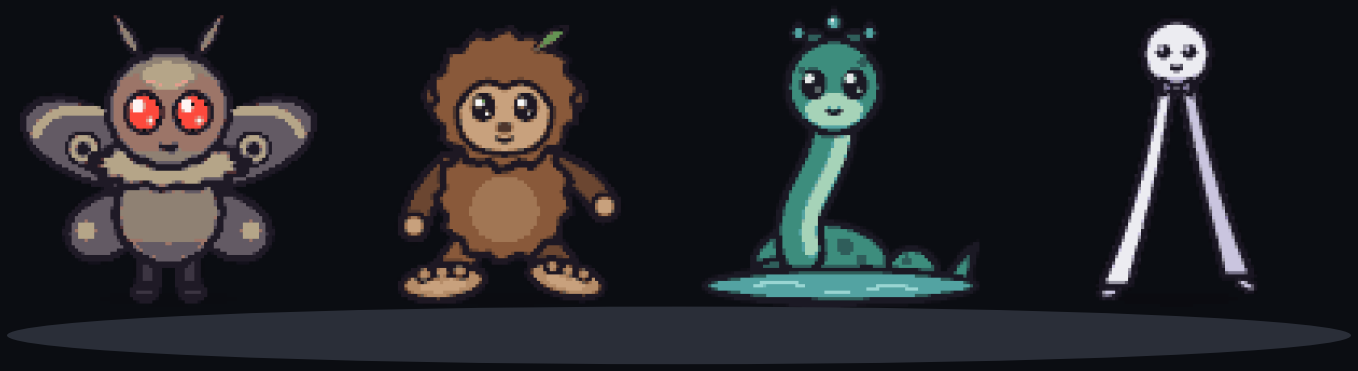
DEPT. OF ODD FAUNA / FIELD OFFICE 7

Cryptlings

A field guide for the keeper

How to raise a creature nobody believes in.



Mothman Bigfoot Nessie Fresno Nightcrawler

Waveshare ESP32-C6-Touch-LCD-1.47 / CASE STATUS: UNVERIFIED

WELCOME

What this is

CRYPTLINGS is a pocket field journal for raising a cryptid. You pick an egg, keep it warm, and raise the thing that hatches into an adult over about a week of real time. Cryptids are nocturnal, so they wake at dusk and sleep through the day, and the whole game runs on the real clock.

How you raise it decides what it becomes. A well kept cryptid grows into a **Legend**. One that was left alone too much becomes a **Blurry Photo**. One that was spoiled with treats turns out to be a **Hoax**. Nothing ever dies. The worst that happens is a fuzzy picture and a lot of sulking.

Everything is played on the touch screen. Tap to choose, drag in some games, and **hold** for the big things (incubating an egg, cuddling, releasing an adult). A button on the side wakes the screen.

The screen at a glance



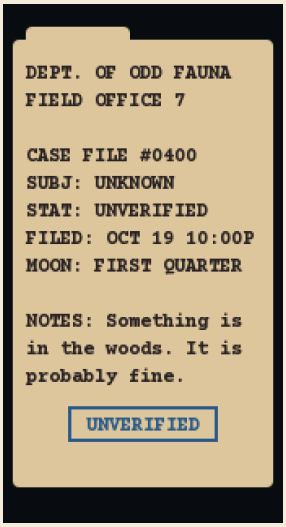
The Den at night

Part	What it does
Top bar	The time (left) and battery (right).
Tabs	**Den** (your pet), **Care** (everything you can do), **File** (its bio, photos and evidence), **More** (almanac and settings).
Polaroid	Your cryptid in its home scene, with the real moon phase, fog and fireflies. The stamp in the corner says how believable it is, and the label shows its stage.
Five pips	Its needs. See the next page.
Hint line	The amber line tells you what it wants most right now.
Big buttons	The left one is always the best thing to do right now. **CARE** opens the full list.

FIRST NIGHT

Getting started

The first time it boots, the field office types up a fresh case file. Tap to move on to the specimen tray.



A new case file



The specimen tray



Hold to incubate



Name it

Step	How
1. Pick an egg	Swipe left or right, or tap the arrows, to look at all four eggs.
2. Incubate	Press and **hold** HOLD TO INCUBATE until the bar fills.
3. Name it	Tap **ANOTHER** until you like the name, then **USE IT**.
4. Keep it warm	In the Den, **hold** the egg (or tap WARM) to warm it. Your very first egg hatches in about 10 minutes, any time of day. Later eggs take about 6 hours.
5. Hatch	A polaroid develops and your Whisper appears. Tap to continue.



A warm egg in the Den



Developing...



Now a Whisper

THE FIVE NEEDS

Keeping it happy

The row of five icons under the polaroid shows its needs. Full bars are good. They drain slowly over time, faster while it is awake. When one gets low, the hint line tells you, and the left big button changes to the fix.

Need	What it means	How to fill it
Belly	Hunger.	FEED (its staple food), or a TREAT.
Cheer	Happiness.	PLAY a minigame, pat it, cuddle it.
Rest	Sleepiness.	Let it sleep through the day. LIGHTS gives a short nap.
Mystique	How mysterious it stays. Cryptids should not be seen too clearly.	HIDE. Bigfoot also needs you to answer hikers.
Tidy	Burrs, mud and fog in its fur.	CLEAN.

Touching your pet



Tap: a pat



Hold: a cuddle

Tap the cryptid to pat it. A few pats an hour help its Cheer; after that it is simply pleased.

Hold the cryptid for a long cuddle. That gives more Cheer. If it is asleep, a cuddle tucks it in instead.

While it is still an egg, tapping or holding it keeps it warm.

The stamp

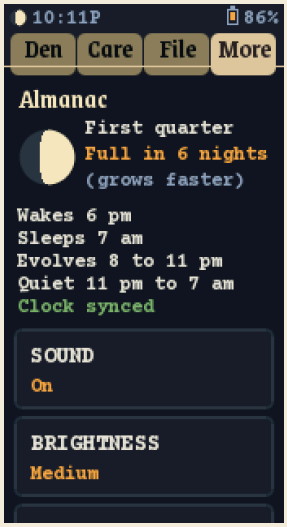
The stamp on the polaroid shows how far along the investigation is: **UNVERIFIED** while young, **SIGHTED** as a teen, then **CONFIRMED** (Legend), **INCONCLUSIVE** (Blurry Photo) or **DEBUNKED** (Hoax).

THE CLOCK

Night and day



Asleep in the day



The almanac

Cryptids keep night hours. The almanac at the top of the **More** tab shows tonight's schedule and the moon.

Time	What happens
6 pm	It wakes up. Prime time for care and games.
8 to 11 pm	The evening window. Growing up (evolving) only happens now, while you are there to see it.
11 pm to 7 am	Quiet hours: no unprompted sounds.
Dawn	Tuck it in with **LIGHTS** so it sleeps well.
7 am	Asleep until dusk. Let it rest.

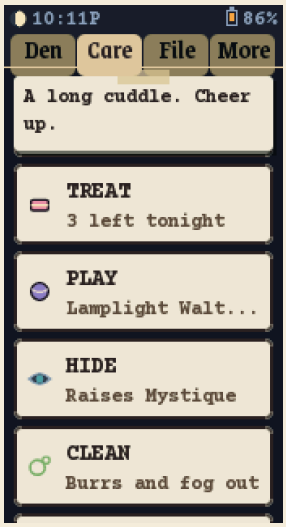
You can still visit during the day. Feeding or playing with a sleeping cryptid works, but it wakes up grumpy and gets less out of it. The left button says **SHH** while it sleeps (tap it to tuck it back in).

The moon is real. A full moon nearby makes it grow a little faster.

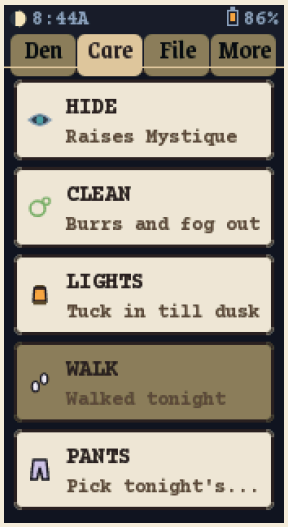
No internet needed. If you set up WiFi when flashing, the clock syncs itself when it starts. Otherwise set it by hand under More, SET CLOCK. The almanac says **Clock synced** when the time is confirmed.

THE CARE TAB

Everything you can do



The Care list



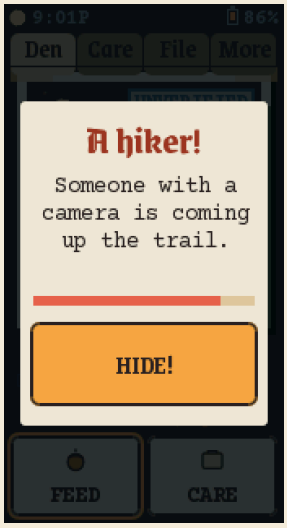
Scroll for more

The **Care** tab lists every action. Scroll for more. Each row has a short note under it.

Action	What it does
FEED	Its staple food. Fills Belly.
TREAT	Something special. Fills Belly and a bit of Cheer. Only 3 a night, and too many over its life leads to a Hoax.
PLAY	Its 20 second minigame. The better you do, the more Cheer.
HIDE	Raises Mystique.
CLEAN	Burrs and fog out. Fills Tidy.
LIGHTS	One short nap a night. At dawn it tucks it in until dusk.

Species extras

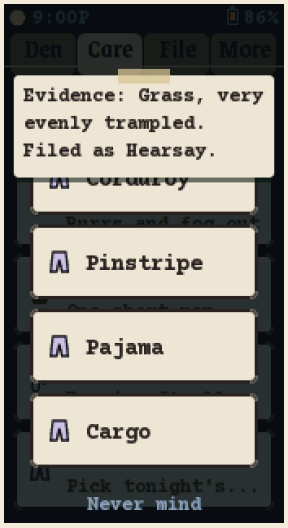
Cryptid	Extra row	Why it matters
Mothman	LAMP	He adores the porch light and it cheers him up. Leave it on too long and he bonks the glass and sees spirals for a while (no games until it wears off).
Bigfoot	FORAGE, hikers	FORAGE finds him wild berries. Sometimes a hiker with a camera comes up the trail. Tap **HIDE!** within 10 seconds or Mystique drops.
Nessie	TOP UP LOCH	Her Loch Level drains. Top it up with a bucket of rain or she gets uneasy.
Nightcrawler	WALK, PANTS	He needs one walk a night (the Evening Stroll) or he sulks. Each night he eyes one pair of pants; pick the right one for a dignified twirl.



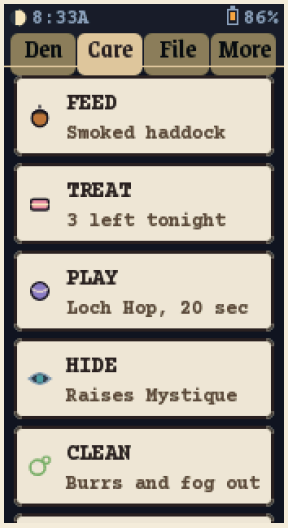
Bigfoot: a hiker!



Hid in time



Nightcrawler: pants



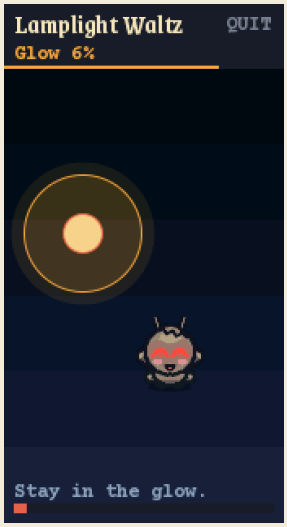
Nessie's care list

PLAY

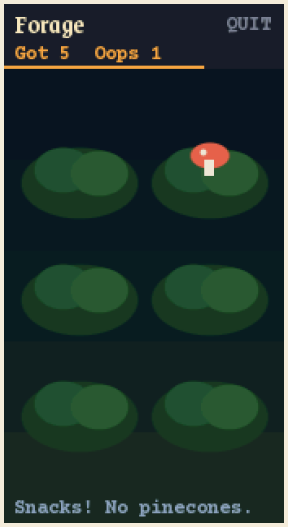
The four minigames

Each cryptid has its own 20 second game, started from **PLAY** (or **WALK** for the Nightcrawler). When it ends, a card shows how you did; tap to continue. Tap **QUIT** at the top to leave early.

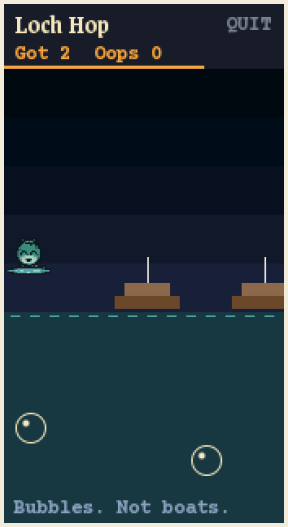
Game	Cryptid	How to play
Lamplight Waltz	Mothman	**Drag** the glowing light. Keep Mothman inside the glow. The Glow meter at the top fills while he is in it.
Forage	Bigfoot	**Tap** the berries and mushrooms as they pop out of the bushes. Skip the pinecones, they count as Oops.
Loch Hop	Nessie	**Tap** the bubbles as they drift past so Nessie gulps them. Do not tap the rowboats.
Evening Stroll	Nightcrawler	Tap **LEFT** and **RIGHT** in turn, steadily. Rushing or double tapping makes him wobble.



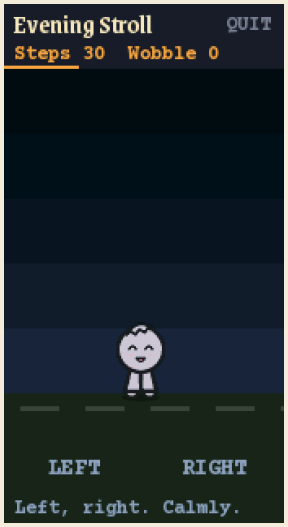
Lamplight Waltz



Forage



Loch Hop



Evening Stroll



The result card

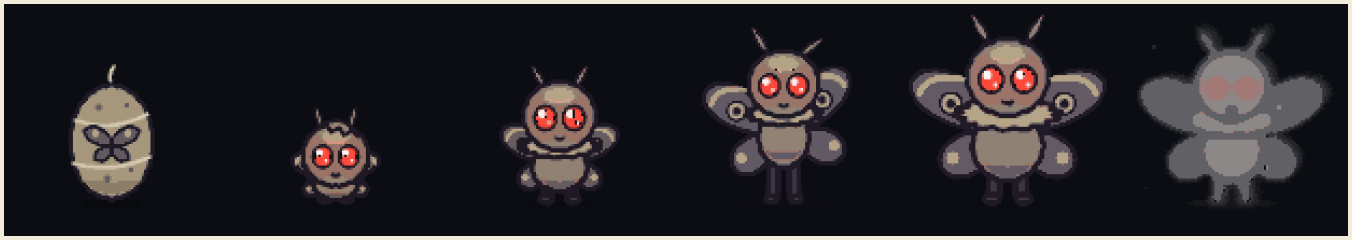
A great game sometimes turns up a piece of **evidence** for the File (more on that later).

Playing with a sleeping cryptid works, but the card will note that it was grumpy about it.

GROWING UP

From egg to adult

Your cryptid grows through four young stages, then becomes an adult. Growing up only happens live, during the 8 to 11 pm evening window, so you never miss it.

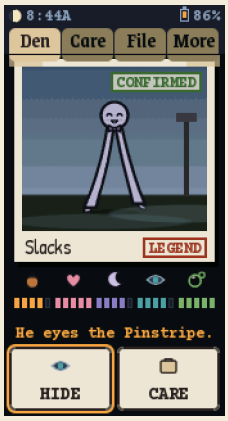


Egg Whisper Rumor Sighting Legend Blurry Photo

Stage	Roughly how long	To move on
Egg	10 minutes for your first, then about 6 hours	Keep it warm.
Whisper (baby)	About 1.5 days	Keep it fed.
Rumor (kid)	About 3 days	Decent overall care.
Sighting (teen)	About 3 days	Then it becomes an adult.
Adult	For good	Legend, Blurry Photo or Hoax.

Nessie grows a little slower than the rest. A pet that has been neglected still grows up eventually; it never gets stuck.

Which adult?



A Legend



A Blurry Photo



The reveal card

Legend: good care across its whole life, and it stayed well hidden.

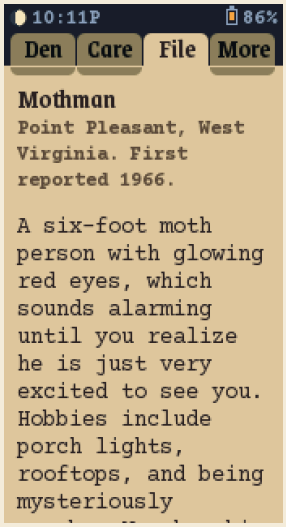
Blurry Photo: too much neglect, or too often seen (for Bigfoot, missed hikers add up fast).

Hoax: spoiled. Lots of treats and not much else. Turns out it was a guy in a suit.

When it grows up, a card explains why: how many care lanterns it earned (out of 5), whether it stayed hidden, and how many rough nights it had.

THE FILE TAB

The case file



Bio and origin



Photo record

The **File** tab is your cryptid's case file: where it was first reported, its bio, its quirk, and a **photo record** with a polaroid for every stage it has reached.

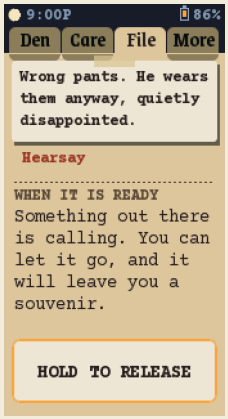
Evidence

While you care for it, clues turn up: a muddy footprint, a red glint in a window, a grainy CCTV still. Each one is filed by how convincing it is:

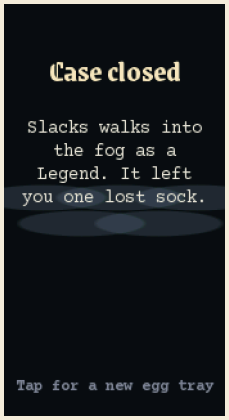
Tier	Example
Hearsay	Snapped branch
Anecdote	A neighbor's late-night story
Eyewitness	Two red dots on a doorbell cam
Photographic	Plaster footprint cast
Irrefutable	A clear photo. Nobody believes it.

There are 16 pieces per species. Your collection is kept across pets.

Releasing an adult



Hold to release



Case closed



A fresh tray

Some time after it grows up, an adult starts to hear something calling. The hint line says so, and the File tab shows **HOLD TO RELEASE**.

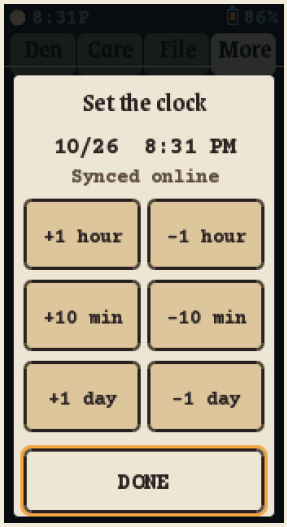
Hold it to let your cryptid walk into the fog. It leaves you a souvenir, its polaroids and evidence stay in the File, and you get a new egg tray to start again. Releasing is never required.

THE MORE TAB

Settings



Settings



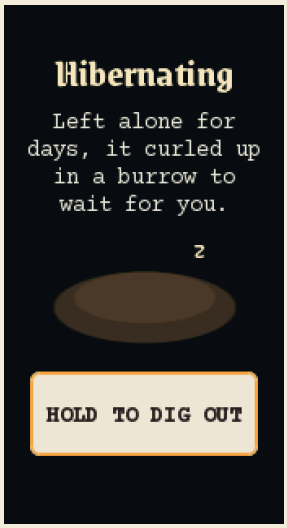
Set the clock

Setting	What it does
SOUND	On, chimes only, or off. It stays quiet from 11 pm to 7 am regardless, and makes at most a few unprompted sounds a day.
BRIGHTNESS	Low, medium or high.
SCREEN OFF AFTER	30 seconds, 1 minute or 2 minutes without a touch.
BATTERY SAVER	On by default. While the screen is off, it rests deeply and checks in once a minute. Turn it off for a faster wake at the cost of battery.
SET CLOCK	Nudge the date and time by the hour, 10 minutes or a day.
START OVER	Wipes the current pet and gives you a new egg tray. Asks first.

Left alone too long



Hibernating



Dug out

Time keeps passing while the screen is off or the device is powered down, and your cryptid keeps living through it (at half speed, so a day away is not a disaster).

If it is left for more than 3 days, it curls up in a burrow to wait for you. **Hold** HOLD TO DIG OUT and it comes back sleepy, a bit muddy, and very glad to see you.

THE BUTTON

Waking and powering off



Keep holding



Powered off

Do this	With the screen...	What happens
Tap	off	The screen wakes instantly, right where you left it.
Tap	on	Lights out now.
Hold 3 s	either	Soft power off. After a second a "Keep holding" ring appears; let go to cancel.

Soft power off saves everything first. Press the button to turn it back on: it restarts in about a second and your cryptid is there, with the time away counted.

The screen also turns itself off after the time you choose in More. Touch is switched off while the screen is dark, so use the button to wake it.

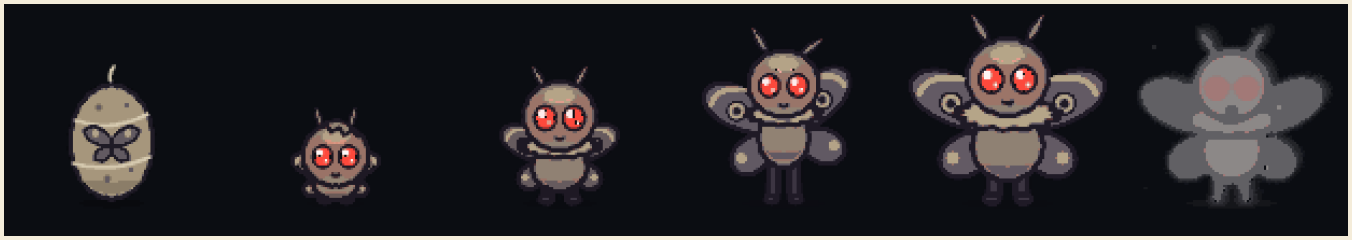
The small BOOT button on the board can wake the screen and turn it off too, but it cannot power the device back on.

Battery: the device checks the battery once a minute while the screen is on. If it reads empty twice in a row, it saves and powers itself off to protect the battery.

SPECIMEN 1 OF 4

Mothman

A six-foot moth person with glowing red eyes, which sounds alarming until you realize he is just very excited to see you. Hobbies include porch lights, rooftops, and being mysteriously nearby. Now has his own festival, a shiny statue, and no idea how to handle the fame.



Egg Whisper Rumor Sighting Legend Blurry Photo

Field	Notes
First reported	Point Pleasant, West Virginia. First reported 1966.
Quirk	Loves light. Too much lamp time and he bonks into the glass.
Staple food	Moth dust cakes
Treat	Porch-light candy
Minigame	Lamplight Waltz
When hidden	"Hiding behind the porch light. The eyes give it away."
Name ideas	Sir Flutters, Porchlight Pete, Lampwick, Dusty, Gloweyes, Lamp Boy
Leaves behind	A single dusty wing scale
If it's a Hoax	"It was an owl in a cape the whole time."

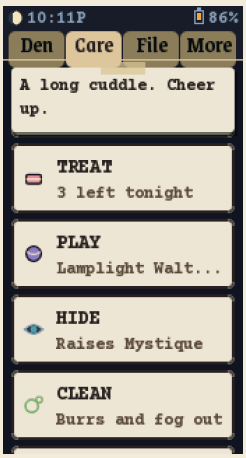
Keeper's tip: Loves light. Use the LAMP row to cheer him up, but switch it off before he gets dizzy.



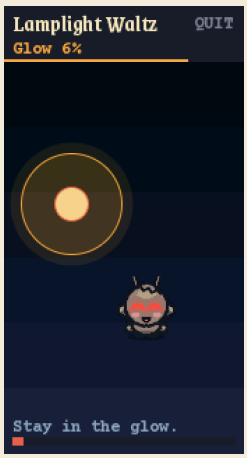
The egg



A Whisper at night



His care list



Lamplight Waltz

SPECIMEN 2 OF 4

Bigfoot

The forest's most dedicated hiker and star of a 1967 film he insists was shot without his consent. Shoe size: yes. Photos in focus: zero. Enjoys berries, long walks, and leaving exactly one footprint, just enough to start an argument.



Egg Whisper Rumor Sighting Legend Blurry Photo

Field	Notes
First reported	Pacific Northwest woods. Filmed at Bluff Creek, California, in 1967.
Quirk	Very camera shy. Hikers with cameras cost extra Mystique.
Staple food	Trail mix
Treat	Huckleberry tart
Minigame	Forage
When hidden	"Behind a tree. Mostly. The feet are sticking out."
Name ideas	Big Doug, Mossfoot, Gerald, Stompy McPine, Harold, Squatchy
Leaves behind	A giant plaster footprint cast
If it's a Hoax	"It was a guy in a suit. You can see the zipper."

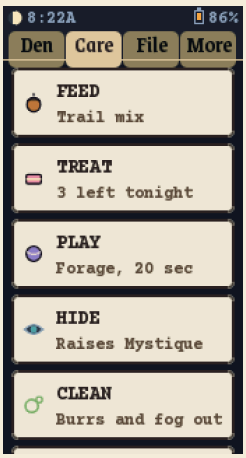
Keeper's tip: The Mystique challenge. Hikers with cameras show up; answer every one with HIDE! in time.



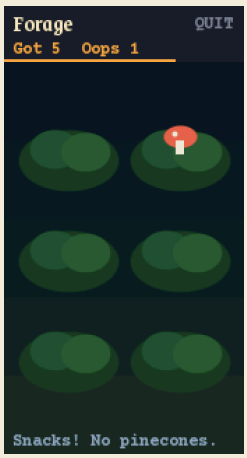
The egg



A Whisper, asleep



His care list

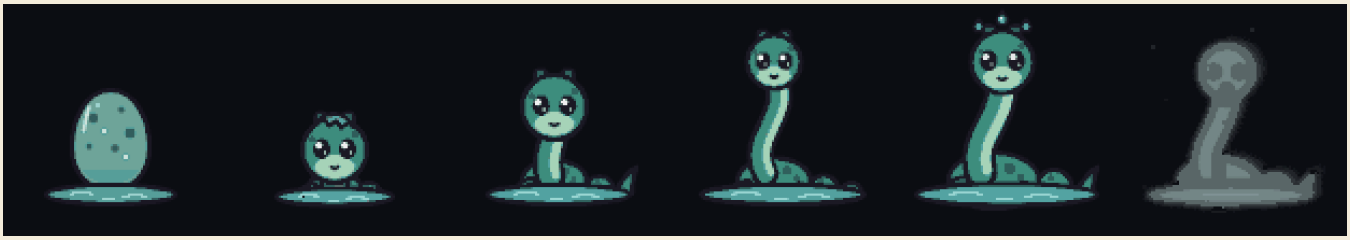


Forage

SPECIMEN 3 OF 4

Nessie

Scotland's most famous introvert. Her best-known photo (1934) was later admitted to be a toy submarine with a fake head, which she maintains was a body double. Damp, polite, and world class at holding her breath.



Egg Whisper Rumor Sighting Legend Blurry Photo

Field	Notes
First reported	Loch Ness, Scotland. Rumored for roughly 1,500 years.
Quirk	Needs her Loch Level topped up. Slow to grow, calm as an adult.
Staple food	Smoked haddock
Treat	Shortbread finger
Minigame	Loch Hop
When hidden	"Submerged. Just a ripple now."
Name ideas	Wee Nessa, Lady Ripple, Bubbles, Morag, Shortbread, Wee Humphrey
Leaves behind	A smooth loch pebble
If it's a Hoax	"It was a toy submarine with a sculpted head. Again."

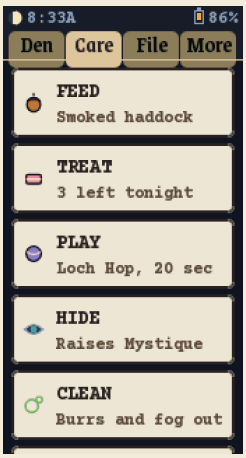
Keeper's tip: Slow to grow and calm as an adult. Keep her Loch Level topped up.



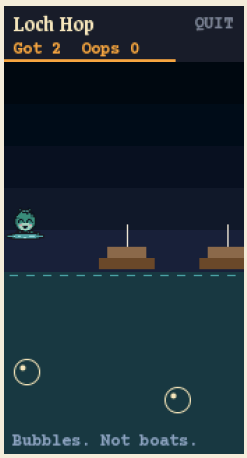
The egg



A Whisper, asleep



Her care list

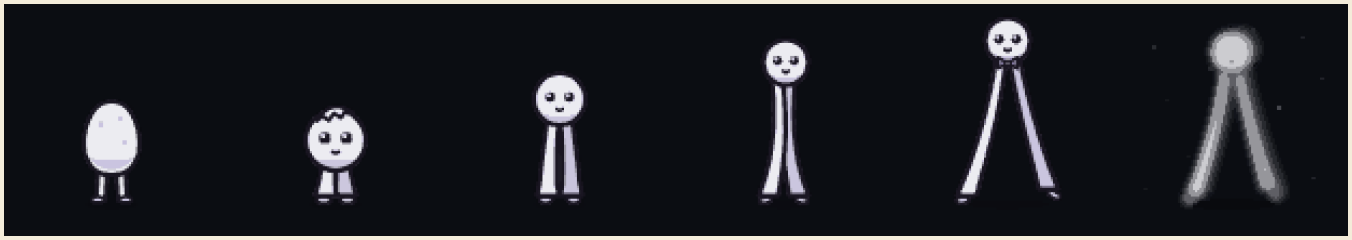


Loch Hop

SPECIMEN 4 OF 4

Fresno Nightcrawler

A small white someone who is about 90% legs and 10% pants. He is not here to haunt you. He is just going for a walk. Very calmly. At 2 a.m. Please respect the stroll.



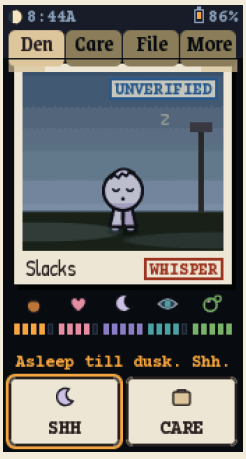
Egg Whisper Rumor Sighting Legend Blurry Photo

Field	Notes
First reported	Fresno, California. Caught on a security camera in 2007.
Quirk	Needs his walks. Fussy about his pants.
Staple food	One grape, slowly
Treat	Two grapes, recklessly
Minigame	Evening Stroll
When hidden	"Standing very still. He is a coat rack now."
Name ideas	Slacks, Trouser Tim, Longshanks, Pantaloon, Stilts, Gerald
Leaves behind	One lost sock
If it's a Hoax	"It was two pool noodles in pants."

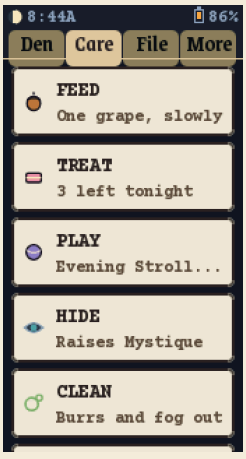
Keeper's tip: Needs one Evening Stroll a night and the right pants. He is not haunting you. He is walking.



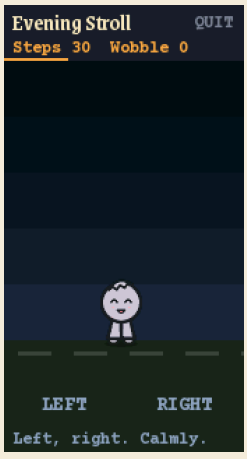
The egg



A Whisper, asleep



His care list



Evening Stroll